Recommendation: Neo4j

Neo4j is the ideal choice for developing XYZ's social networking platform because it is specifically designed for handling connected data, like user relationships, efficiently. Key reasons include:

Graph-Based Data Model: Neo4j naturally represents user relationships and networks, enabling easy implementation of features like "People you may know."

Superior Performance: It handles real-time queries efficiently, such as finding mutual connections or suggesting friends, without relying on resource-intensive joins.

Scalability: The database scales horizontally, making it suitable for managing large and growing social networks.

Flexibility: Neo4j's schema-less design adapts easily to changes in data structure, a common need for dynamic platforms.

Cost Efficiency: Built for graph operations, it reduces processing and resource requirements compared to traditional relational databases.

Security and Availability: Neo4j offers robust security features and high availability, ensuring data integrity and system reliability.

While SQL Server is excellent for relational data, it struggles with the complexity and performance demands of highly connected datasets. Neo4j is the more appropriate solution for efficiently managing user connections and delivering real-time recommendations in a cost-effective manner.

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